CHAPTER 9

Exponential function and continuous models

Chapter outline

Objectives. Use algebraic properties; differentiate; study growth or decay ; link the exponential and geometric sequences.
Prerequisites. Powers, geometric sequences, differentiation and sign.
Annual timeline. 2·11 February: 8 h

Diagnostic check: six questions, 10 minutes

Answer without looking at your notes. Indicate the questions for which help is needed. This diagnostic test is not graded.

1. Simplify 2 $^{3} \times 2^{4}$.

2. Express 3 $^{-2}$.

3. Solve 2 $x + 1 = 5$.

4. Differentiate $x^2 + 2x$.

5. A decrease of 20% gives which multiplier?

6. For a geometric sequence $u_0 = 5, q = 2$, calculate u_n.

After the diagnostic check. Go over the flagged concepts with the teacher; redo a similar question, then explain the rule used.

Oral work and logic. Explain the difference between a continuous rate and a discrete multiplier; present an inequality proved via the minimum of a difference.

Investigate before formalising

Compare the increments of e^x and the values of the function around 0, with several positive steps. Carry out three Euler steps and explain the rule chosen.

Organisation. Individual work 5 min, discussion in pairs 5 min, whole-class sharing 5 min. Keep a record of an attempt, even an unfinished one. A conjecture must then be justified.

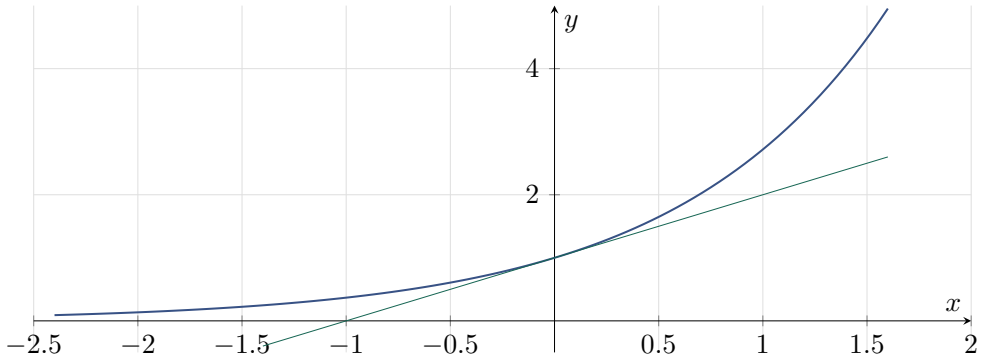
9.1 Defining a new function

Definition and results

The exponential function is the unique function f differentiable on $\mathbb{R}$ satisfying $f' = f$ and $f(0) = 1$. Its existence and uniqueness are assumed. It is denoted exp, then e^x with $e = \exp(1) \approx 2{,}71828$. The number e is a constant; x is the variable. The exponential is strictly positive.

Status and justification. Existence and uniqueness assumed, in line with the syllabus. The positivity is deduced, after the algebraic properties assumed below, from $\exp(x) = \exp(\frac{x}{2})^2$ and $\exp(x)\exp(-x) = 1$.

Worked example. $\exp(0) = 1$, $\exp(1) = e$, $\exp'(0) = 1$. The tangent at 0 is therefore $y = 1 + x$. The notation e^x extends the properties of powers to any real exponent.



e^x (blue) and its tangent $1 + x$ at 0 (green).

Watch out

$e^0 = 1$, not 0. The function never takes the value 0, even for negative x.

Immediate application. What is the equation of the tangent to e^x at 1?

9.2 Algebraic properties and comparisons

Definition and results

For all real numbers x, y, $e^{x+y} = e^x e^y$, $e^{-x} = \dfrac{1}{e^x}$, $e^{x-y} = \dfrac{e^x}{e^y}$. For integer n, $(e^x)^n = e^{nx}$. The function is strictly increasing on $\mathbb{R}$, therefore $e^u = e^v \iff u = v$ and $e^u < e^v \iff u < v$.

Status and justification. The addition formula is assumed in the common core; it can be explored further via uniqueness. Positivity and $\exp' = \exp > 0$ show that it is strictly increasing. This justifies the equivalences for equations and inequalities.

Worked example. $e^{2x}e^{1-x} = e^{x+1}$. $e^{3x-2} = e^{x+4}$ is equivalent to 3 $x - 2 = x$ +4, so x=3. $e^{2x} \leq 1 = e^0$ is equivalent to $x \leq 0$.

Watch out

e^{x+y} is a product, never in general $e^x + e^y$. We do not solve e^x = 2 with a logarithm not studied in Première.

Immediate application. Simplify $\dfrac{e^{3x}}{e^{x-1}}$; solve $e^{x+2} > e^{2x}$.

9.3 Differentiate and study

Definition and results

For real a, $t \mapsto e^{at}$ is differentiable and its derivative is ae^{at}. For $e^{at+b} = e^b e^{at}$, the derivative is ae^{at+b}. The product and quotient rules apply with derivatives already known. The sign of the exponential often simplifies the study of the sign of the derivative.

Status and justification. The differentiation formula for e^{at} is assumed; the case with b follows from it by taking out the constant factor e^b. The general chain rule is not needed here.

Worked example. For $f(x) = (x+1)e^{-x}$, $f'(x) = e^{-x} - (x+1)e^{-x} = -xe^{-x}$. Since $e^{-x} > 0$, the derivative has the sign of $-x$: global maximum 1 at 0.

Watch out

Do not forget the factor a or the minus sign in e^{-x}. The exponential factor is positive, not necessarily increasing.

Immediate application. Find g' for $g(t) = 3e^{-2t}$ and study how it varies.

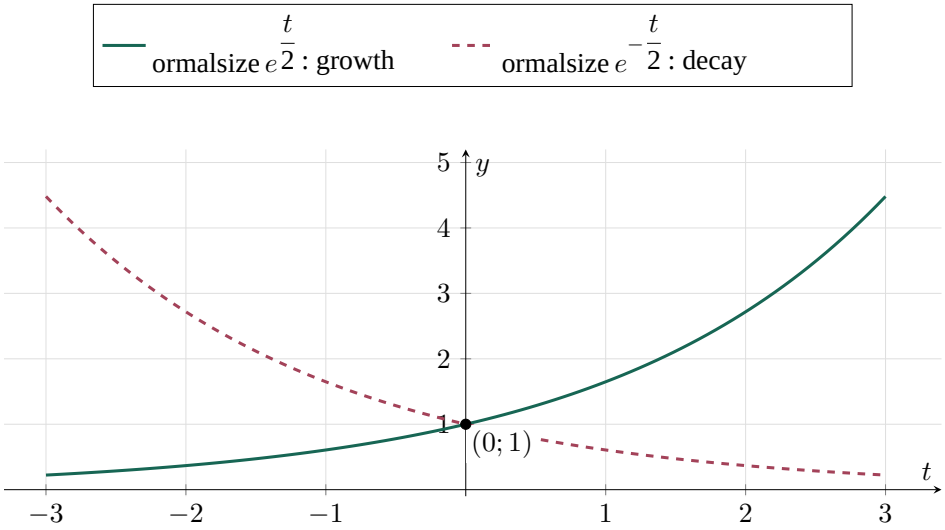
9.4 From discrete to continuous

Definition and results

A model $Q(t) = Q_0 e^{kt}$, with $Q_0 > 0$, represents growth if $k > 0$, decay if $k < 0$, and a constant quantity if $k = 0$. For a fixed step h, $\dfrac{Q(t+h)}{Q(t)} = e^{kh}$. The values at integer times form a geometric sequence with common ratio e^k. The unit of k is the reciprocal of the unit of time.

Status and justification. The ratio comes from $e^{k(t+h)} = e^{kt}e^{kh}$. The direction of variation follows from $Q\prime(t) = kQ_0e^{kt}$ and the positivity of the remaining factor.

Worked example. $Q(t) = 100e^{-0{,}2t}$, t in hours: $Q(0) = 100$, $\dfrac{Q(t+1)}{Q(t)} = e^{-0{,}2}$. A simulation can look for the first whole number of hours at which Q falls below 50; the exact equation is not solved using logarithms in this chapter.



The curves corresponding to $k = \dfrac{1}{2}$ and $k = -\dfrac{1}{2}$ are symmetric about the vertical axis. The line styles also distinguish them without colour.

Watch out

The relative rate per discrete unit of time is $e^k - 1$, not exactly k; they are close only for small k.

Immediate application. For $Q(t) = 5e^{0{,}3t}$, express $Q(n)$ and $\dfrac{Q(t+2)}{Q(t)}$.

9.5 Build numerically and prove an inequality

Definition and results

To approximate the solution of $y' = y$, $y(0) = 1$ with a step h, Euler's method replaces the increment by hy : $y_{k+1} = (1+h)y_k$. On [0; 1] with $h = \frac{1}{n}$, the approximation of e is $\left(1+\frac{1}{n}\right)^n$. This construction is experimental. The inequality $e^x \geq 1 + x$ is obtained by studying a function.

Status and justification. For $g(x) = e^x - 1 - x$, $g'(x) = e^x - 1$, negative if x<0 and positive if x>0. The minimum is $g(0) = 0$, which proves the inequality; equality only at 0. The convergence of Euler's method is not proved here.

Worked example. With n=2, Euler's method gives $y_0 = 1, y_1 = 1{,}5, y_2 = 2{,}25$. With n=10, (1 ,1)$^{10} \approx 2{,}59374$. We compare with e; we do not confuse an approximate value with the definition of the function.

Watch out

A graph showing a curve above a line does not prove the inequality for all real numbers.

Immediate application. Show that $e^{2x} \geq 1 + 2x$ for all real x.

Exercise path

Start with exercises 1 and 2. Then choose exercise 3 or 4 without help. Exercises 5 to 7 are a bank of transfer, investigation or programming tasks: the teacher assigns one. Exercise 8 is revisited later.

Exercise 9.1 · Transform

For every real x, consider the expressions

$$A = e^x e^{2-x}, \qquad B = \frac{(e^{2x})^3}{e^x}, \qquad C = e^{-x}(e^x + 1).$$

1. Simplify A and B justifying each grouping of exponents.
2. Expand then simplify C. Explain why a sum does not simplify in the same way as a product.

Exercise 9.2 · Equations and inequalities

Consider an equation and an inequality in a real unknown x :

$$e^{2x-1} = e^{x+3} \quad \text{and} \quad e^{-3x} \geq e^{x-2}.$$

1. Solve each one in $\mathbb{R}$, citing the property of the exponential function that allows the comparison of the exponents.
2. When solving the inequality, explain at which step the direction of the inequality changes. Give the solution set as an interval.

Exercise 9.3 · Product and maximum

The function f is defined on [0; 4] by $f(x) = xe^{-x}$.

1. Calculate $f\prime(x)$, then study its sign on the interval.
2. Draw the variation table of f. Deduce its maximum and the x-value where it is attained.
3. Check that the values at the endpoints do not give a larger maximum. Keep the exact values.

Exercise 9.4 · A modelled population

The following two parts are independent.

Part A - A population. A population is modelled by $P(t) = 200e^{0,1t}$ where $t \geq 0$ is the time elapsed in years. $P(t)$ is a theoretical count, which need not be an integer.

1. Determine the initial count, then the multiplier between times t and $t+1$. Hence deduce the exact annual rate and its percentage, rounded to the nearest hundredth.
2. Explain why this model cannot necessarily describe a real population indefinitely.
3. **Part B - Two curves.** In the same coordinate system, sketch the graphs of $t \mapsto e^{\frac{t}{2}}$ and $t \mapsto e^{-\frac{t}{2}}$. Describe how each one varies, their common point and their symmetry. Label each curve clearly.

Exercise 9.5 · Search for a threshold

The amount of a substance, in milligrams, is modelled at time $t \geq 0$ by $Q(t) = 80e^{-\frac{t}{2}}$, and t is expressed in hours. Checks take place at integer times $n = 0, 1, 2, \ldots$. We seek the first check for which the quantity is strictly less than 10 mg.

1. Write an algorithm to find this first integer. Include a bound on the number of iterations and specify what the program returns if the bound is reached.
2. Run the algorithm, then numerically check the quantity at the index found and at the previous index.
3. Justify, using the decrease of Q, that this double check shows that it is indeed the first index. Do not use logarithms.

Exercise 9.6 · A symmetry

Consider the function f defined on $\mathbb{R}$ by $f(x) = e^x + e^{-x}$.

1. Study the parity of f and interpret the result for its curve.
2. Prove that $f(x) \geq 2$ for every real x, choosing a method. State the equality case.
3. Suggest checking the result by a second method, using a square or a study of variations.

Exercise 9.7 · Uniqueness under an assumption

Extension. Assume that the exponential function has already been constructed. Let f a function differentiable on $\mathbb{R}$ which satisfies $f'(x) = f(x)$ for every real x and $f(0) = 1$. Set $g(x) = f(x)e^{-x}$.

1. Calculate g' and explain why g is constant on $\mathbb{R}$.

2. Determine this constant and then deduce from it the expression of f.

3. Does this proof establish the existence or the uniqueness of the required function? Justify.

Exercise 9.8 · Delayed review

Define the sequence (u_n) by $u_n = e^{2n+1}$ for every natural number n.

1. Prove that this sequence is geometric, then give its first term and common ratio.

2. Calculate $u_0 + u_1 + u_2$ in exact form. Compare the direct calculation with using a formula for a sum.

Independent work. Do only the task assigned at the end of the session, as set in the dated scheme of work: 10-20 min maximum. The exercises depend on the concepts already studied; some questions are therefore postponed. Revisit exercise 8 one week after the chapter (10 min). If the planned time is exceeded, note the difficulty and bring your attempts; do not try to do the whole reserve.

To be done in the CQFD textbook

These exercises are done in your textbook. The scheme of work gives the session; they replace the homework planned for that day (10 to 20 minutes in total).

CQFD, exercise 18 p. 187, questions a, b and c. Simplify the products and quotients, citing the property of exponentials used.

CQFD, exercise 30 p. 187, questions a, b and c. Solve the three inequalities and write the solution sets in the form of intervals.

MCQ 1: understand and choose

Five teaching questions with a single answer. Choose one answer per question; then explain one distractor. This chapter format does not reproduce the official format of the EAM.

1. $e^0 =$

   A. 0
   B. 1
   C. e
   D. -1

2. $e^x e^y =$

   A. e^{x+y}
   B. e^{xy}
   C. $e^x + e^y$
   D. e^{x-y}

3. Derivative of e^{-2x} :

   A. e^{-2x}
   B. $2e^{-2x}$
   C. $-e^{-2x}$
   D. $-2e^{-2x}$

4. $e^x = 1$ is equivalent to

   A. $x = 1$
   B. $x = e$
   C. $x = 0$
   D. no solution

5. The sign of e^{-x} is

   A. negative if x>0
   B. always strictly positive
   C. zero at 0
   D. variable

MCQ 2: understand and choose

Five teaching questions with a single answer. Choose one answer per question; then explain one distractor. This chapter format does not reproduce the official format of the EAM.

1. $e^{2x} < e^3$ is equivalent to

   A. $x < 3$
   B. $x > \frac{3}{2}$
   C. $x < \frac{3}{2}$
   D. $x < \sqrt{3}$

2. $u_n = e^{3n}$ has common ratio

   A. e^3
   B. 3

C. e

D. $3e$

3. Tangent to e^x at 0:

A. $y = x$

B. $y = ex$

C. $y = 1$

D. $y = x + 1$

4. Derivative of xe^x :

A. e^x

B. $(x + 1)e^x$

C. xe^x

D. xe^{x-1}

5. $e^x \geq 1 + x$ has equality

A. for every x

B. at 1 only

C. at 0 only

D. never

True or false? Justify.

1. $e^{2x} = 2e^x$ for all x.

2. The function $t \mapsto e^{-3t}$ is decreasing.

3. A continuous rate k=0.1 corresponds exactly to a 10% increase in one unit of time.

Personal review

I apply the power rules; I know it is positive; I differentiate with the factor; I separate
model, exact calculation and simulation.
For each objective, indicate: mastered without help; achieved with help; needs more work. Write an example and
a mistake to avoid.